Self-management Skills

The big idea

Self-management means taking responsibility for your own behaviour, feelings, time and well-being. Employers value people who can manage stress, stay motivated without constant supervision, set goals and use time well. This chapter covers **stress management**, **self-awareness**, **self-motivation**, **goal setting** and **time management**.

Stress and stress management

Stress is the body's and mind's reaction to pressure or a demanding situation. A little stress can push us to perform, but too much harms health, sleep and studies.

Common causes for students: exams, peer pressure, family expectations, too many tasks, conflicts and illness.

STRESS MANAGEMENT TECHNIQUES

- **Time management** – plan and prioritise work so it does not pile up.
- **Physical exercise and yoga** – release tension and improve mood.
- **Meditation and deep breathing** – calm the mind.
- **Healthy diet and enough sleep** (8 hours for teenagers is a good target).
- **Positive thinking** and talking to family, friends or a counsellor.
- **Taking breaks and hobbies** – music, sports, nature walks, holidays.

AVOIDING THE TASK IS NOT STRESS MANAGEMENT

Postponing work feels good for a moment, but the pending task increases stress later. Break it into small parts and start.

Self-awareness

Self-awareness is knowing your own strengths, weaknesses, interests, values and emotions. It is the first step to self-improvement.

- **Strengths**: what you are good at (e.g. drawing, maths, explaining things).
- **Weaknesses**: areas to improve (e.g. stage fear, handwriting).
  You can find them by self-reflection, feedback from teachers and friends, and by noticing which activities energise you.

Self-motivation

Motivation is the inner push that makes us act. **Self-motivation** means pushing ourselves without needing others to remind us.

Type	Source	Example
Internal (intrinsic)	Inner joy, interest, satisfaction	Reading because you love stories
External (extrinsic)	Rewards, marks, praise, money, fear of punishment	Studying for a prize

Qualities of self-motivated people: they know what they want, are focused, stay positive after failure, and keep learning.

BUILD SELF-MOTIVATION

Find what you truly enjoy, set small goals, celebrate small wins, and keep reminding yourself *why* the goal matters to you.

Goal setting: SMART goals

A goal should be **SMART**:

- **S**pecific – clear and exact ("score 90 in IT", not "do well").
- **M**easurable – progress can be checked.
- **A**chievable – realistic for you.
- **R**ealistic / Relevant – fits your bigger aims.
- **T**ime-bound – has a deadline.

TURNING A WISH INTO A SMART GOAL

Wish: "I want to type fast." SMART goal: "I will practise typing for 20 minutes daily using a typing tutor and reach 30 words per minute by 31 December."

Time management

Four steps help you manage time:

1. **Organise** – make a list or timetable of tasks.
2. **Prioritise** – do important and urgent tasks first.
3. **Control** – avoid distractions like social media during study time.
4. **Track** – check at the end of the day what got done and adjust.

Quick recap

- Stress management: time planning, exercise, yoga, meditation, sleep, diet, positive thinking, hobbies.
- Self-awareness = knowing strengths and weaknesses.
- Motivation can be internal (intrinsic) or external (extrinsic).
- Goals should be SMART; time management = organise, prioritise, control, track.

Practice questions

1. Studying because you enjoy learning new things is an example of
   (a) internal (intrinsic) motivation (b) external motivation (c) peer pressure (d) stress
2. In SMART goals, the letter T stands for
   (a) Thoughtful (b) Tested (c) Time-bound (d) Targeted
3. Which of these is a healthy stress management technique?
   (a) Skipping meals to save time (b) Staying awake all night before every test (c) Keeping all worries to yourself (d) Regular exercise and deep breathing
4. Knowing your own strengths and weaknesses is called
   (a) self-motivation (b) self-awareness (c) self-control (d) time management
5. Which step of time management involves doing urgent and important work first?
   (a) Organising (b) Tracking (c) Controlling (d) Prioritising
6. Getting a cash prize for winning a quiz is a form of
   (a) intrinsic motivation (b) extrinsic motivation (c) self-awareness (d) stress
7. Write any four techniques for managing stress.
8. What is a SMART goal? Frame one SMART goal for yourself.

Answers: 1. a 2. c 3. d 4. b 5. d 6. b 7. see notes 8. see notes